OneDrive sync problems and fixes

Article KB0010073 | Owner: Messaging & Collaboration | Subcategory: OneDrive / SharePoint sync | Applies to: Windows 11 (23H2/24H2) on Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air, OneDrive sync client (version?>=?22.XXX), SharePoint Online libraries accessed via OneDrive

Summary

OneDrive sync issues can appear as a red-X icon, sync-paused notifications, conflict files, or a SharePoint library that refuses to update. Most problems stem from invalid characters in file names, storage limits, outdated clients, or temporary network glitches. The following article outlines quick self-checks, a user-driven reset procedure, and the steps the Messaging & Collaboration service-desk team follows to restore sync.

Symptoms

- OneDrive tray icon shows a red?X or gray cloud with a pause symbol
- Notification: "We're having trouble connecting to OneDrive" or "Sync paused"
- File Explorer shows a yellow warning triangle on OneDrive folder
- SharePoint library appears offline or displays "Sync error - please try again"
- Presence of files named *_ConflictCopy_* or similar conflict markers
- OneDrive reports "Storage full" even though quota appears available

Common causes

- File or folder names containing characters blocked by OneDrive (e.g., \\, /, :, *, ?, ", <, >, |) or beginning/ending with a space
- Local OneDrive folder exceeds the user's 50?GB mailbox-plus-archive storage limit or the device's disk space is low
- Outdated OneDrive client missing recent bug fixes
- Intermittent network loss or VPN (GlobalProtect) disconnect causing authentication token expiration
- Conflicting edits on the same file creating sync conflict copies
- Conditional Access or device compliance policies blocking sync
- Corrupted local OneDrive cache or configuration

Initial checks

Before attempting a reset, verify the most common blockers. These checks take only a minute and often resolve the issue without further action.

1. Look at the OneDrive icon in the system tray (Windows) or menu bar (macOS). Note whether it shows a red?X, gray cloud, or normal blue cloud.
2. Right-click the icon -> View sync problems. Record any error codes or messages displayed.
3. Open File Explorer (Windows) or Finder (macOS) and navigate to the OneDrive folder. Check for files with yellow warning triangles or names containing _ConflictCopy_.
4. Confirm you have internet access: open a browser and go to https://portal.office.com. If you are on VPN, ensure GlobalProtect shows 'Connected'.
5. Check available storage: right-click the OneDrive icon -> Settings -> Account -> See storage usage. Ensure you are below your limit.

Self-help procedure - Reset OneDrive client

If the initial checks show no obvious blocker, resetting the OneDrive client clears its local cache and forces a fresh sign-in. This restores sync in the majority of cases without data loss.

1. Close all Office applications (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook) to avoid file locks.
2. Press Win?+?R, type %localappdata%\Microsoft\OneDrive\onedrive.exe /reset, and press Enter. On macOS, open Terminal and run: open /Applications/OneDrive.app --args --reset.
3. Wait for OneDrive to disappear from the tray/menu bar, then relaunch it: Start -> OneDrive (Windows) or open OneDrive from Applications (macOS).
4. Sign in with your Acme Global email address when prompted. Allow the app to complete the initial sync - this may take several minutes depending on library size.

5. Verify the OneDrive icon returns to a normal blue cloud and that the sync problems list is empty.

Service-desk procedure

Agents follow this workflow when a user reports OneDrive sync issues that persist after basic checks. The goal is to isolate the cause, apply the appropriate fix, and confirm restoration of sync.

1. Greet the user and confirm ticket details (device, OS, OneDrive version, specific symptom).
2. Run the initial checks listed in the 'Initial checks' section and document any error messages or conflicting files found.
3. If invalid file/folder names are identified, guide the user to rename the items (remove blocked characters, trim leading/trailing spaces) and then retry sync.
4. If storage quota is exceeded, advise the user to delete or move files to SharePoint/Teams, or request a quota increase via the IAM team.
5. If the client is outdated (>=?2?weeks behind the latest release), direct the user to update OneDrive from the Company Portal or via the Microsoft 365 admin center.
6. When sync pauses due to VPN/Network loss, verify GlobalProtect connection status; if disconnected, reconnect and re-authenticate.
7. If conflict files are present, instruct the user to keep the desired version, delete or rename the conflict copy, then resume sync.
8. If none of the above resolves the issue, perform a client reset as described in the 'Self-help procedure' section, capturing logs before and after if needed.
9. After the fix, ask the user to confirm that the OneDrive icon is healthy and that recent changes appear in the cloud within 5?minutes.

Verification

Both users and agents should verify that sync is truly restored before closing the ticket. This prevents premature closure and repeat incidents.

1. Open the OneDrive activity center (click the icon -> View sync problems) and ensure the list is empty.
2. Create a test file (e.g., TestSync.txt) in a synced folder, save it, and confirm it appears in OneDrive web (https://onedrive.live.com) within a minute.
3. Check that the SharePoint library in question shows the latest file version and no sync error banner.
4. If the user uses Files On-Demand, verify that online-only files correctly download when opened.

Prevention tips

Encourage users to adopt habits that reduce the likelihood of future OneDrive sync problems.

1. Avoid using blocked characters in file/folder names; stick to letters, numbers, hyphens, underscores, and periods.
2. Keep the OneDrive client up to date - enable automatic updates via Company Portal.
3. Monitor storage usage monthly; archive old data to SharePoint sites or delete unnecessary files.
4. Maintain a stable network connection; if using VPN, reconnect promptly after any disruption.
5. Regularly review the OneDrive sync problems list and address any warnings immediately.

When to escalate

If the user's OneDrive sync remains unsuccessful after the service-desk procedure (reset, client update, name correction, and quota check) or if the issue is traced to a Conditional Access policy, device compliance failure, or a backend SharePoint service outage, escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration team lead. Include in the escalation: device hostname, OS version, OneDrive version, exact error messages, screenshots of sync problems, and any relevant Intune compliance or Conditional Access logs. For widespread outages affecting multiple users, also notify the Identity & Access Management and Network Support groups as appropriate.

Keywords: OneDrive not syncing, OneDrive sync paused, OneDrive red X, SharePoint library not syncing, sync conflict files, OneDrive full, reset OneDrive, OneDrive troubleshooting, OneDrive error 0x80070005, OneDrive invalid characters, OneDrive storage quota, OneDrive GlobalProtect VPN